

01

THE PROBLEM □

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM (Recommended opening definition): Religious language is discourse about transcendent reality whose central problem is how finite human concepts can be meaningful without reducing their object to finite categories.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Univocal language (same sense as for creatures) makes God finite/anthropomorphic; equivocal language (wholly different sense) makes God-talk meaningless/unknowable.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

The Logical Positivist attack (Ayer): "God exists" is unverifiable → literally meaningless (see Paper-I Logical Positivism).

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answer-use: ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM (Recommended opening definition): Religious language is discourse about transcendent reality whose central problem is how finite human concepts can be meaningful without reducing their object to finite categories.

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02

HOW WE SPEAK — Analogy, Symbol, Negation □

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

(a) Analogy (Aquinas — 2024 PYQ): religious language is analogical — between univocal and equivocal.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Analogy of attribution — "God is good" because God is the cause/source of goodness in creatures.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

A symbol (unlike a mere sign) participates in the reality it points to and "opens up levels of reality otherwise closed".

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

So "good" applies proportionally, truly but not identically. → preserves meaning without anthropomorphism.

ANSWER LINE: Analogy preserves ordered similarity, symbol mediates participation and negation removes creaturely limitation; each seeks meaningful reference without literal anthropomorphism.

03

WHETHER IT STATES FACTS — Cognitive vs Non-cognitive □

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Cognitivist (realist): religious statements are genuine truth-claims — "God exists" is true or false, asserting a fact about reality (Aquinas, Hick, Swinburne). □

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Ayer (Logical Positivism): non-cognitive because meaningless (unverifiable) — the hostile version.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Cognitivism treats religious claims as truth-apt, whereas non-cognitivism emphasises attitude, commitment or use; these are semantic functions, not automatically exclusive categories.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

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04

COMPARISON GRID □□

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

□ The strong answer: religious language is neither literal nor meaningless — analogy/symbol give it cognitive meaning (realist), while non-cognitivists (Braithwaite/Wittgenstein) capture its practical/moral force but at the cost of its truth-claim; the believer's own intent is cognitivist.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

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UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

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05

FOUNDATIONAL STATEMENT BANK □□

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

1. □ Aquinas locates God-talk between univocal sameness and equivocal disconnection through analogy.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

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CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

3. □ Braithwaite analyses religious assertion through commitment to a moral way of life and its sustaining stories.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

2. □ Tillich treats religious symbols as participatory and God as being-itself rather than one being among others.

ANSWER LINE: 1. □ Aquinas locates God-talk between univocal sameness and equivocal disconnection through analogy.

06

APPLIED-QUESTION DRILLS □□

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

6. [Secular vs religious] "In what sense is the secular use of language different from the religious use?" (2018, 10m) → §9.6 — function, not vocabulary.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

2. [Analogical] "Analogical nature of religious language (Aquinas)." (2024) → §2(a).

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

11. [Analogy] "The analogical nature of religious language." (2024, 10m) → §9.1 + §9.8 — add Scotus for the contrast.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

6. [Secular vs religious] "In what sense is the secular use of language different from the religious use?" (2018, 10m) → §9.6 — function, not vocabulary.

ANSWER LINE: 1. [Symbolic] "Is religious language symbolic? / Tillich on symbol." (2025, 2023) → §2(b).

07

PARITY BENCH — the same three exits, East and West □□

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: A complete answer must keep two axes separate: how religious predicates refer and whether religious utterances assert facts.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

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UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

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